

ASSIGNMENT - CO1 - AT3

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Course Code :- ITA1434

Course Name :- Ethical Hacking

During a social engineering assessment, you successfully manipulate a receptionist into revealing sensitive information by pretending to be a grieving relative of an employee. Evaluate the ethics of this pretext, considering psychological harm versus test realism.

A) Using a grieving relatives as a pretext can make a social engineering test very realistic, but it raises serious ethical concerns.

⇒ The scenario takes advantage of the receptionist's emotions, sympathy, and trust, which may cause psychological stress or emotional harm.

⇒ such a test can be ethical only if it has prior authorization, clearly defined limits, and proper safeguards.

⇒ the assessment should avoid unnecessarily distressing employees and should focus on testing security weaknesses rather than exploiting personal trauma.

A safer approach would be to use a realistic but less emotionally harmful pretext, such as pretending to be a vendor, employee, or IT support person. This can still test whether the receptionist follows security procedures without deliberately causing emotional distress.

Conclusion:-

Test realism is important, but it should not come at the cost of an employee's psychological well-being. Ethical social engineering assessments should balance realistic testing, informed authorization, privacy, and minimizing harm.